

Framing the Constructs of Public Accountability in Government Service

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I Introduction

In an article entitled “The Meaning of Public Accountability Law Constitutional Administrative”, public accountability is regarded as the hallmark of modern democratic governance¹. Democracy remains a paper procedure if those in power cannot be held accountable in public for their acts and omissions, for their decisions, their policies, and their expenditures.

The same article articulated that “public accountability” as a concept, however, is rather exclusive.² It is hurrah-word, like learning, responsibility, or solidarity- nobody can be against it. Accountability has moved further beyond its bookkeeping origins and has become a symbol for good governance, both in the public and in the private sector. Accountability does not refer to sovereigns holding their subjects to account, but to the reverse, it is the authorities themselves who are being held accountable by their citizens.³ Public accountability is also regarded as an integral and inevitable commitment of the government to its people.⁴

In a democratic country like the Philippines, public accountability is embodied in the 1987 Philippine Constitution which provides that, “public office is a public trust”. This tenet affords that public officers and employees must at all times be accountable to the people, serve with utmost responsibility, integrity, loyalty and efficiency; act with patriotism and justice and lead modest lives (Article XI, Section 1).⁵

Another comprehensive law passed to address and curb the commission of malfeasance in government is Republic Act No. 3019 or the Anti-Graft and Corruption Practices Act. In Section 1 of this law, it states that: “It is the policy of the Philippine Government, in line with the principle that a public office is a public trust,

¹ Uni Assignment (n.d.) The Meaning of Public Accountability Law Constitutional Administrative Retrieved July 2020 from <https://www.uniassignment.com/essay-samples/law/the-meaning-of-public-accountability-law-constitutional-administrative-essay.php>

² *Id.*

³ *Id.*

⁴ Goetz, Anne Marie (2005) Reinventing Accountability: Making Democracy Work for Human Development: Introduction

⁵ The 1987 Constitution of the Republic of the Philippines (February 2, 1987) Article XI: Accountability of Public Officers. Retrieved July 2020 from <https://www.ncda.gov.ph/integrity-development-action-plan/related-idap-laws/accountability-of-public-officers/>

to repress certain acts of public officer and private persons alike which constitute graft and corrupt practices which may lead thereto”.⁶

In the government’s desire of achieving its mandate of providing the basic services to the public, equal importance is given to ensure that every public servant possesses utmost accountability in its discharge of official functions.⁷ With this, public officials and employees are expected to maintain honesty, integrity and accountability in the public service. However, the issues of ethics and accountability pose a continuing challenge to the Philippine government.⁸

The Civil Service Commission, as the watchdog and oversight agency has adopted positive measures including the dissemination of information programs and workshops authorizing merit increases beyond regular progression steps to motivate public officials and employees in raising the general level of observance of these standards.

Despite the government’s effort to strengthen the practice of public accountability, issues arise whether the latter is really understood by the workers of the government. Are the concepts and standards of public accountability cascaded across all levels in the organization and whether accountability is really present in every organization of the government?

If so, at what level in the organization has public accountability manifested? Is it really felt by the employees or does it remain to be unheeded? Are government employees’ understanding of public accountability reflective of the government’s standards?

With this, the paper aims to provide a framework for the constructs of public accountability among government employees in the City of Iloilo. The varying views and understanding of government employees on public accountability will also be identified. It further attempts to provide policy recommendations on public accountability framework to serve as insights to the government as it envisions a more accountable and productive public servant.

⁶ Republic Act No. 3019. Anti-Graft and Corruption Practices Act (August 17, 1960) Retrieved on July 2020 at https://lawphil.net/statutes/repacts/ra1960/ra_3019_1960.html

⁷ The 1987 Constitution of the Republic of the Philippines (February 2, 1987) Article XI: Accountability of Public Officers. Retrieved on July 2020 from <https://www.ncda.gov.ph/integrity-development-action-plan/related-idap-laws/accountability-of-public-officers/>

⁸ Civil Service Commission (2000). Ethics and Accountability: The Philippine Experience .Retrieved on July 2020 at <https://silo.tips/download/ethics-and-accountability-the-philippine-experience>

II Methodology

This study uses literature study in discussing the issues described in this paper. Literature studies undertaken include the analysis of literature sources (books, scientific journals, accountability articles, internet sources and legal documents) in order to come up with reviews, summaries and analysis relative to significant concepts of the issue identified. The primary sources of information used in this paper are journals, articles and legal documents that have relevance and significance in the study.

Based on the analysis and consideration of these literary sources, the paper has identified the various concepts of accountability which helped guide the researcher to develop its questionnaire. A semi-structured questionnaire or discussion guidelines were used in conducting interviews among government employees in the City of Iloilo. Respondents were selected based on their service tenure, status of employment, job level and gender. Prior to the conduct of the interview, respondents were made to fill-out the Individual Questionnaire and Informed Consent Form and were oriented on the scope and intention of the study. After which, the interview was done through an audio-recording, as allowed also by the respondents.

Qualitative data gathered were then transcribed, manually indexed and categorized based on the identified concepts on accountability. There were 25 concepts enumerated by the researcher as a result of the literature studies conducted.

Frequency of responses were then tabulated and ranked to determine the most used or mentioned concept of accountability.

In the discussion and analysis phase, the paper presents the most common concept identified by the respondents and researcher develops a framework on the constructs of public accountability which is the focus of this study.

III Results and Discussions

Literature Concept of Public Accountability

Accountability is one of these golden concepts that no one can be against. It is increasingly used in political discourse and policy documents because it conveys an image of transparency and trustworthiness. Accountability may be defined in several ways. First it is the responsibility of a government and its agents to achieve previously set objectives and to account for them in public; secondly it is the commitment required from public officials- individually and collectively- to accept public responsibility for their actions and inactions; and finally, it is the obligation of a subordinate to keep his or her superior informed of the execution of responsibility.⁹

⁹ Fox and Meyer (1995) ACCOUNTABILITY IN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION AND MANAGEMENT: A THEORETICAL EXPOSITION (1-2). Retrieved on July 2020 at <https://repository.up.ac.za/bitstream/handle/2263/24172/02chapter2.pdf?sequence=3&isAllowed=y>

Kathe Callahan in her article “Elements of Effective Governance” stresses that public sector accountability is the obligation of authorities to explain publicly, fully and fairly, how they carry out, or fail to carry out, responsibilities that affect the public in important ways. It is an obligation to account for one’s action.¹⁰

According to Melvin J. Dubnick, one of the leading academic authorities on public sector accountability, “Accountability has traditionally been regarded as the means used to control and direct administrative behavior by requiring ‘answerability to some external authority’”.¹¹

Additionally, Barbara Romzek and Patricia Ingraham, who have written extensively on accountability in government, note that “accountability, in its most fundamental sense, refers to answerability to someone for expected performance. Those to whom one is answerable must be legitimate sources of control and their expectations for performance must be legitimate as well.”¹²

James Fesler and Donal Kettl divide accountability into two dimensions: one is accountability; faithful obedience to the law, to higher officials’ directions, and to standards of efficiency and economy. The other is ethical behavior; adherence to moral standards and avoidance of the appearance of unethical behavior.¹³

Jay Shafritz defines accountability in broader terms: “Administrative accountability is the concept that officials are to be held answerable for general notions of democracy and morality as well as for specific legal mandates.

Accountability, defined as the quality or state of being accountable; especially an obligation or willingness to accept responsibility or to account for one’s actions, government employees to manifest accountability are expected to provide accurate information about one’s activities or behavior, at the same time is able to evaluate its behavior with reference to certain standards and rules thereby recognizing one’s obligations and accepting responsibility for one’s actions.”¹⁴

This notion carries two basic conditions: answerability which is the obligation of the public employees to inform and explain what they are doing and enforcement in which the capacity of agencies to impose sanctions to those who have violated their public duties are measured. If this process is too complex to identify contributions to specific outcomes, then holding individuals accountable for undesirable outcomes

¹⁰ Callahan, Kathe (2006) Elements of Effective Governance

¹¹ Dubnick, M. (1998). Clarifying accountability: An ethical theory framework. Retrieved July 2020 at https://scholars.unh.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1022&context=polisci_facpub

¹² Romzek and Ingraham (2000). Direct accountability: Chances and risks. Retrieved July 2020 at <https://journals.uic.edu/ojs/index.php/fm/article/download/1218/1138>

¹³ Fesler, J. and Kettl, D. (1996), The Politics of Administrative Process, Chatham House: Chatham, NJ, p. 317

¹⁴ Shafritz, J.M. (1992) The Harper Collins Dictionary of American Government and Politics, Harper Collins: New York

becomes difficult. As a result, individuals as well as organizations as a whole escape the blame and avoid accountability.¹⁵

There exist, however, bureaucratic biases in many definitions of accountability that assume a clearly defined higher authority; standards of efficiency, economy and performance; terms are clearly stated in unambiguous manner and processes and procedures are in place that promote accountable behavior.¹⁶

Public accountability means the obligation to answer publicly- to report, to an acceptable standard of answering, for the discharge of responsibilities that affect the public in important ways. It is the obligation to answer for a responsibility conferred. The obligation to answer publicly arises as a fairness obligation whenever authorities intend something that would affect the public in important ways. Thus, the obligation extends beyond answering for responsibilities formally or legally concerned.¹⁷

Public Accountability is not just another political catchword; it also refers to institutionalized practices of account giving. Accountability may be defined as a social relationship in which an actor feels an obligation to explain and to justify his or her conduct to some significant other.¹⁸

The ethical base of public accountability is the level of accord created between government authority and the government's accountability to the public. The true function of public accountability should be not to focus on negative aspects only.¹⁹

In passing a negative judgment some sort of sanctions is imposed on the accountable person. These sanctions can be highly formalized, such as fines, disciplinary measures or even penal sanctions, but often the punishment will only be implicit or informal.²⁰

The Code of Conduct and Ethical Standards for Public Officials and Employees spells out in fine detail the do's and don'ts for government officials and employees in and out of the workplace. Additionally, administrative accountability sets forth a concept that officials are to be held answerable for general notions of democracy and morality as well as for specific legal mandates (R.A. No. 6713). The Code has expressly enumerated various norms or standards that a government official should adhere to, one of which is justness and sincerity. These norms or standards that relate to public accountability are described as follows²¹ :

¹⁵ Schedler, Andreas (1999). Conceptualizing Accountability'. P.14

¹⁶ Callahan, Kathe (2006) Elements of Effective Governance

¹⁷ Uni Assignment (n.d.). The Meaning of Public Accountability Law Constitutional Administrative Essay, Retrieved on July 2020 at <https://www.uniassignment.com/essay-samples/Uniaw/the-meaning-of-public-accountability-law-constitutional-administrative-essay.php#ftn86>

¹⁸ *Id.*

¹⁹ *Id.*

²⁰ *Id.*

²¹ Republic Act No. 6713. Code of Conduct and Ethical Standards for Public Officials and Employees. (February 20, 1989). Retrieved July 2020 at https://lawphil.net/statutes/repacts/ra1989/ra_6713_1989.html

- *Commitment to Public Interest* - Public officials and employees shall always uphold the public interest over and above personal interest. All government resources and powers of their respective offices must be employed and used efficiently, effectively, honestly and economically, particularly to avoid wastage in public funds and revenues;
- *Professionalism* - Public officials and employees shall perform and discharge their duties with the highest degree of excellence, professionalism, intelligence and skill. They shall enter public service with utmost devotion and dedication to duty. They shall endeavor to discourage wrong perceptions of their roles as dispensers or peddlers of undue patronage;
- *Justness and Sincerity* - Public officials and employees shall remain true to the people at all times. They must act with justness and sincerity and shall not discriminate against anyone, especially the poor and the underprivileged. They shall at all times respect the rights of others, and shall refrain from doing acts contrary to law, good morals, good customs, public policy, public order, public safety and public interest. They shall not dispense or extend undue favors on account of their office to their relatives whether by consanguinity or affinity except with respect to appointments of such relatives to positions considered strictly confidential or as members of their personal staff whose terms are coterminous with theirs;
- *Political Neutrality* - Public officials and employees shall provide service to everyone without unfair discrimination and regardless of party affiliation or preference;
- *Responsiveness to the Public* - Public officials and employees shall extend prompt, courteous, and adequate service to the public. Unless otherwise provided by law or when required by the public interest, public officials and employees shall provide information of their policies and procedures in clear and understandable language, ensure openness of information, public consultations and hearings whenever appropriate, encourage suggestions, simplify and systematize policy, rules and procedures, avoid red tape and develop an understanding and appreciation of the socio-economic conditions prevailing in the country, especially in the depressed rural and urban areas;
- *Nationalism and Patriotism* - Public officials and employees shall at all times be loyal to the Republic and to the Filipino people, promote the use of locally produced goods, resources and technology and encourage appreciation and pride of country and people. They shall endeavor to maintain and defend Philippine sovereignty against foreign intrusion.

- *Commitment to Democracy* - Public officials and employees shall commit themselves to the democratic way of life and values, maintain the principle of public accountability, and manifest by deeds the supremacy of civilian authority over the military. They shall at all times uphold the Constitution and put loyalty to country above loyalty to persons or party; and
- *Simple Living* - Public officials and employees and their families shall lead modest lives appropriate to their positions and income. They shall not indulge in extravagant or ostentatious display of wealth in any form.

Another innovation by the government to encourage public accountability, efficiency and effectivity in the delivery of public service, R.A. No. 9485 otherwise known as the Anti-Red Tape Act of 2007 as amended by R.A. No. 11032 or the Ease of doing Business and Efficient Government Service Delivery Act of 2018 was created. This Act intends to improve efficiency in the delivery of government service to the public by reducing bureaucratic red tape, prevent graft and corruption, and provide penalties for any infraction. These addendums, expressly stipulated in Section 4 of JMC 2019-001 (IRR of R.A. No. 11032, 2019) resemble innovation and possess new standards of public accountability.²²

Varying Understanding on the Concepts of Public Accountability

From the literature study conducted, the researcher identified the 25 concepts on public accountability. These include: responsibility, answerability, performance, trustworthiness, good governance, integrity, transparency, acceptance, justness, and commitment. Additional concepts are punishment, norms and standards, loyalty, efficiency, fairness, timeliness, completeness, professionalism, responsiveness, legitimate, faithfulness, ethical, moral standards, sanction, and fines.

²² Republic Act No. 11032. Anti-Red Tape Act of 2007. (May 28, 2018) Retrieved July 2020 at https://www.google.com/search?q=Republic+Act+No.+11032&oeq=Republic+Act+No.+11032&aqs=edg_e.69i57j0i512l3j0i390i395l2i69i64.236j1j4&sourceid=chrome&ie=UTF-8

Table 1: Summary of Frequency Responses on the Concept of Public Accountability

CONCEPTS	F R E Q U E N C Y						TOTAL	NO. OF RESPONSES	FREQUENCY TOTAL
	2019-11-001	2019-11-002	2019-11-003	2019-11-004	2019-11-005	2019-11-006			
1 Responsibility/Responsible	6	6	3	5	0	7	27	5	135
2 Answerability/Answerable	4	2	1	1	0	0	8	4	32
3 Performance/Perform	0	0	1	0	6	2	9	3	27
4 Public Trust/ Trust-worthiness	1	0	4	0	0	1	6	3	18
5 Good Governance	1	1	1	0	1	0	4	4	16
6 Integrity	4	2	0	0	0	0	6	2	12
7 Transparency	2	0	1	1	0	0	4	3	12
8 Acceptance	0	1	0	1	2	0	4	3	12
9 Justice/Justness/Justify	1	0	0	0	3	0	4	2	8
10 Commitment	2	0	0	0	1	0	3	2	6
11 Punishment	0	0	0	0	5	0	5	1	5
12 Norms & Standards	0	0	0	0	2	0	2	1	2
13 Loyalty	0	1	0	0	0	0	1	1	1
14 Efficiency	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1	1
15 Fairness	0	0	0	0	1	0	1	1	1
16 Timeliness	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1
17 Completeness	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1
18 Professionalism	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1
19 Responsiveness/Responsive	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	1	1
20 Legitimacy	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
21 Faithfulness/Obedience	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
22 Ethical	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
23 Moral Standard	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
24 Sanction	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
25 Fines	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0

Table 1 shows the varying understanding of respondents on what public accountability is. Of the 25 identified concepts of public accountability, 19 were mentioned by the respondents and 6 were not. Out of the 19 mentioned concepts, the concept of responsibility was the most mentioned per interviewee, followed by the concept of performance and punishment, which is mentioned most by one respondent only. However, based on the number of responses (i.e. out of 6 respondents); responsibility, answerability and good governance are the most mentioned concepts. The 6 concepts that were not mentioned at all by the respondents include: legitimate, faithfulness/obedience, ethical, moral standard, sanction, and fines.

Table 2: Top Ten (10) Most Frequently Mentioned Concept of Public Accountability

CONCEPTS	F R E Q U E N C Y						TOTAL	NO. OF RESPONSES	FREQUENCY TOTAL
	2019-11-001	2019-11-002	2019-11-003	2019-11-004	2019-11-005	2019-11-006			
1 Responsibility/Responsible	6	6	3	5	0	7	27	5	135
2 Answerability/Answerable	4	2	1	1	0	0	8	4	32
3 Performance/Perform	0	0	1	0	6	2	9	3	27
4 Public Trust/ Trust-worthiness	1	0	4	0	0	1	6	3	18
5 Good Governance	1	1	1	0	1	0	4	4	16
6 Integrity	4	2	0	0	0	0	6	2	12
7 Transparency	2	0	1	1	0	0	4	3	12
8 Acceptance	0	1	0	1	2	0	4	3	12
9 Justice/Justness/Justify	1	0	0	0	3	0	4	2	8
10 Commitment	2	0	0	0	1	0	3	2	6

Table 2 shows the top 10 most frequently mentioned concepts of public accountability which include; responsibility - having been mentioned 27 times by 5 respondents, answerability, performance, trustworthiness, good governance, integrity, transparency, acceptance, justness, and commitment.

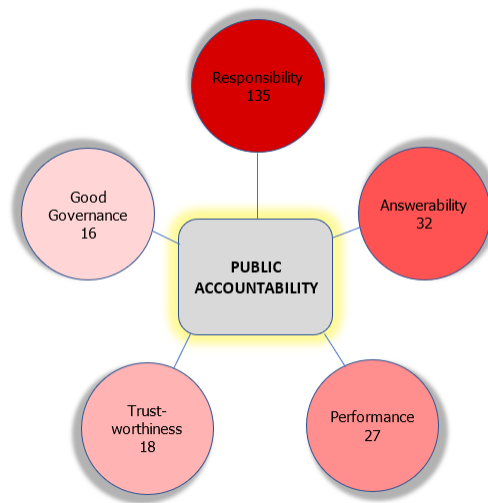


Figure 1: Framework of Public Accountability

Based on the study conducted, the researcher has identified the five fundamental concepts on the understanding of public accountability by government employees. These include responsibility, answerability, performance, trustworthiness, and good governance.

Responsibility. Accountability is defined as the obligation or willingness to accept responsibility or to account for one's actions.²³ In this study, respondents elaborated accountability as being able to perform their assigned duties and responsibilities as required by their position. This is also manifested by being able to respond effectively and promptly to the needs and requests of the public that they serve. While government employees are expected to evaluate its behavior with reference to certain standards and rules, respondents in the study also highlighted that having a sense of responsibility means providing accurate information to the stakeholders and clientele at the same time ensuring that it conforms with the policies and procedures of the agency.

Answerability. The respondents narrated that in the exercise of one's responsibility, a public servant should not merely possess the ability to perform its obligations but more importantly must be able to accept the consequence of the wrong doings or inadequacy in the action of assigned tasks. When this happens, government employees should also rectify the same mistakes. Accountability, in this context carries two basic conditions: answerability which is the obligation of the public employees to inform and explain what they are doing and enforcement in which the

²³ Meriam-Webster Dictionary (n.d). Retrieved July 2020 at <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/accountability>

capacity of agencies to impose sanctions to those who have violated their public duties are measured. The essence of the public answering obligation requires that authorities propose programs that will affect citizens in important ways, will disclose their intentions and their reasoning, their performance standards, and their actual performance and learning. And they are to meet reasonable standards of timeliness, fairness and completeness in their answering. To install public answering to a reasonable standard, citizens must agree on what it means.

Performance. In the study, respondents shared that to manifest accountability is to perform well in the agency. Government employees should not be contented with mediocre performance but should raise the bar of excellence. With this, appraisal of the employees' performance in the government is in place. Performance accountability is a management and oversight process that makes use of evaluation findings, and many other sources of information to manage the plans, programs, and activities of the government, track performance, report to stakeholders and improve performance.

Trustworthiness. Public accountability requires the ability to be relied on as honest and truthful in delivering public service. To instill public accountability in the eyes of the citizens, a government employee must possess the quality that inspires reliability on his functions of developing products and delivery of services;

Good Governance. The concept of accountability on its own does not necessarily imply public accountability. Public accountability goes hand in hand with representative democracy and its associated rights of citizens and obligations for political representatives and public officials.

IV Conclusion

In this difficult changing environment, accountability is more complicated to assess, measure and evaluate.²⁴

The study infers that understanding of public accountability really varies from one government employee to another. However, from these varying understandings of what public accountability is, five concepts emerged to be common among the respondents. These are responsibility, of which in the interview is meant as the ability to respond to the assigned duties and functions as dictated by position or status; answerability, or taking account to one's action; performance, which highlights that as employees of the government, one must perform beyond the set standards; trustworthiness or being trusted and honest in the performance of responsibility and finally good governance which satisfies the expectation of the general public.

²⁴ Goetz & Jenkins (2005). Accountability Failures and Human Development

V Recommendation

Considering the limitations of this study in terms of the number of respondents, of which this paper only has six (6), and the tool used in analyzing the data, the researcher recommends that another study be conducted to include more employees of the government to be interviewed to achieve a more significant result. Also, NVivo qualitative analysis software is recommended to be used to better analyze the data gathered.

Furthermore, the researcher recommends for quantitative research to be initiated in order to determine whether the framed constructs on accountability is relevant in determining the significant factors that affect the understanding of public accountability. ■

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